

Psalms 91

The Secret Place of the Most High

He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty.*
- 2 *I will say of the LORD, He is my refuge and my fortress: my God; in him will I trust.*
- 3 *Surely he shall deliver thee from the snare of the fowler, and from the noisome pestilence.*
- 4 *He shall cover thee with his feathers, and under his wings shalt thou trust: his truth shall be thy shield and buckler.*
- 5 *Thou shalt not be afraid for the terror by night; nor for the arrow that flieth by day;*
- 6 *Nor for the pestilence that walketh in darkness; nor for the destruction that wasteth at noonday.*
- 7 *A thousand shall fall at thy side, and ten thousand at thy right hand; but it shall not come nigh thee.*
- 8 *Only with thine eyes shalt thou behold and see the reward of the wicked.*
- 9 *Because thou hast made the LORD, which is my refuge, even the most High, thy habitation;*
- 10 *There shall no evil befall thee, neither shall any plague come nigh thy dwelling.*
- 11 *For he shall give his angels charge over thee, to keep thee in all thy ways.*
- 12 *They shall bear thee up in their hands, lest thou dash thy foot against a stone.*
- 13 *Thou shalt tread upon the lion and adder: the young lion and the dragon shalt thou trample under feet.*
- 14 *Because he hath set his love upon me, therefore will I deliver him: I will set him on high, because he hath known my name.*
- 15 *He shall call upon me, and I will answer him: I will be with him in trouble; I will deliver him, and honour him.*
- 16 *With long life will I satisfy him, and shew him my salvation.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 91 is an unattributed song of refuge, likely placed here deliberately after Psalm 90's sober meditation on mortality: having just faced how brief and fragile life is, the Psalter answers with a portrait of the believer safely hidden in God regardless of what threatens. Henry reads it as a psalm for anyone facing danger, plague, or fear in the night; MacArthur-style notes highlight that its promises are addressed specifically to the one who actually dwells with God, not to people in general, and that Satan's misuse of verses 11–12 in tempting Christ shows how easily this psalm's confidence can be twisted into presumption.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens with a conditional portrait: the one who dwells in the secret place of the Most High, who abides under the shadow of the Almighty, is the one who can say of the Lord, 'my refuge and my fortress, my God, in whom I trust.' Safety is tied to nearness, not distance from danger.

Verse 3-8

A sweeping catalog of dangers follows—the snare of the fowler, deadly pestilence, terror by night, arrow by day, plague at noonday—all named specifically rather than vaguely, and all answered by God's covering. Thousands may fall on every side, yet the one sheltered under His wings only watches the reward of the wicked from a place of safety, not because evil does not exist, but because it does not have the final word over the one who trusts.

Verse 9-13

Because the Lord has been made a habitation, no evil shall befall, no plague come near the dwelling. Angels are given charge to keep in all ways, to bear up in their hands, so that the foot need not even strike a stone. The lion, the adder, the young lion, and the dragon—every form of hidden or open threat—are pictured as trodden underfoot, not merely avoided.

Verse 14-16

The psalm closes with God's own speech, confirming the whole preceding promise: because he has set his love upon me, I will deliver him; I will set him on high because he has known my name. He shall call, and I will answer; I will be with him in trouble, deliver and honor him, satisfy him with long life, and show him my salvation. The final word on safety belongs to God Himself, not merely to poetic assurance.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

True security is not the absence of danger but the presence of God—dwelling continually with Him is what places a person under a covering no threat, however varied or terrifying, can finally penetrate. The psalm's promises are addressed to the one who has actually made the Lord a dwelling place and set love and trust upon His name, not offered as a blanket guarantee against all hardship regardless of relationship to Him.

Application for life today.

When fear catalogs its threats—by night, by day, hidden or visible—bring that same specificity to God rather than letting vague anxiety multiply in the dark; name what actually frightens you and set it deliberately under His covering. Notice that these promises belong to the one who dwells with God continually, not occasionally; consider what it would mean to make nearness to Him a daily habitation rather than an emergency measure. Remember Christ's own resistance to Satan's twisting of this psalm in the wilderness: genuine trust rests in God's care, but never presumes on it to force His hand.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific fear—named plainly, as verses 5–6 name theirs—do you need to bring under God's covering rather than let remain vague and looming?

2. What would it look like this week to move from occasionally seeking God in crisis toward actually 'dwelling' with Him as a continual habitation (v. 1)?

3. How does Christ's refusal to misuse this psalm's promises as a test of God (Matthew 4:6–7) shape the difference between genuine trust and presumption?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).